

Debate:
Recognition or Redistribution?
A Critical Reading of Iris Young's *Justice
and the Politics of Difference**

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THE “struggle for recognition” has become the paradigmatic form of political conflict in the late twentieth century. Demands for “recognition of difference” fuel struggles of groups mobilized under the banners of nationality, ethnicity, “race,” gender, and sexuality. In these “post-socialist” conflicts, group identity supplants class interest as the chief medium of political mobilization. Cultural domination supplants exploitation as the fundamental injustice. And cultural recognition displaces socio-economic redistribution as the remedy for injustice and the goal of political struggle.

That, of course, is not the whole story. Struggles for recognition occur in a world of exacerbated material inequality—in income and property ownership; in access to paid work, education, health care and leisure time; but also more starkly in caloric intake and exposure to environmental toxicity, hence in life expectancy and rates of morbidity and mortality. Material inequality is on the rise in most of the world’s countries—in the United States and in Haiti, in Sweden and in India, in Russia and in Brazil. It is also increasing globally, across the line that divides North from South.

How, then, should we view the eclipse of a socialist imaginary centered on “interest,” “exploitation,” and “redistribution”? And what should we make of the rise of a new political imaginary centered on notions of “identity,”

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“difference,” “cultural domination,” and “recognition”? Does this shift represent a lapse into “false consciousness”? Or does it, rather, redress the culture-blindness of a materialist paradigm rightfully discredited by the collapse of Soviet Communism?

If neither of those alternatives seems adequate to the times, then perhaps a third approach is advisable. We might see ourselves as presented with a new intellectual and practical task: that of developing a *critical* theory of recognition, one which identifies and defends only those versions of the politics of difference that coherently synergize with the politics of redistribution.

Political theorists are only beginning to approach this task. Until recently, theorists of distributive justice simply ignored identity politics, apparently assuming that it represented false consciousness. And theorists of recognition likewise ignored distribution, as if the problematic of cultural difference had nothing to do with that of social equality. Both groups, in sum, tended to evade the crucial questions of the day: What is the relationship between redistribution and recognition? Do these constitute two distinct conceptions of justice, belonging to two distinct theoretical paradigms? Or can both be accommodated within a single comprehensive theory? On the practical-political plane, moreover, do struggles for recognition work against struggles for redistribution? Or can both be pursued simultaneously without mutual interference?

Iris Marion Young’s 1990 book, *Justice and the Politics of Difference*, has the merit of inviting such questions.¹ Not that she herself poses them in precisely these terms, to be sure. But Young’s book is unusual in that it aspires to be “bifocal.” It seeks to explicate a theory of justice that encompasses claims of both redistribution and recognition, of both equality and difference, of both culture and political economy. On this ground alone it represents an important step forward in political theory.

Integrating recognition and redistribution in a single theory is no easy task, however. And Young’s effort is not free of difficulties. In what follows, I shall examine the unresolved tensions between the cultural and political-economic dimensions of her framework. By identifying some ambiguities in several of her core conceptions, I shall show that she unselfconsciously mixes elements of the two paradigms, without however successfully integrating them. Because she has not thought through the relations between them, moreover, the two paradigms interfere with one another. The difficulties become especially serious, I contend, when Young seeks to defend a wholesale, undifferentiated and uncritical version of the politics of difference; for this version is at odds with her own professed commitment to the politics of redistribution.

My discussion proceeds in six parts. In the first, I present the general contours of Young’s “bifocal” concern with culture and political economy. Then, in

¹Iris Marion Young, *Justice and the Politics of Difference* (Princeton, N.J.: Princeton University Press, 1990); citations to this volume will appear in the text as page numbers in parentheses.

sections two, three and four, I examine her conceptions of oppression, social group and the “five faces of oppression” respectively. Next, in section five, I consider some real-world applications. I conclude, finally, in section six, by rejecting Young’s wholesale endorsement of the politics of difference and by proposing a more differentiated alternative.

I. THE PREDOMINANCE OF RECOGNITION IN A BIFOCAL SCHEMA

Young herself does not use the terms “recognition” and “redistribution.” In fact, she claims to reject the sort of categorical dualism that would divide issues of justice in this way; she prefers an alternative five-fold classification of oppressions that purports to bypass the distinction between culture and political economy. Moreover, Young explicitly criticizes what she calls the “distributive paradigm” of justice; and she supposes that her framework supersedes it.

Nevertheless, a bifocal interest in recognition and redistribution runs throughout *Justice and the Politics of Difference*. Young’s account of oppression encompasses both injustices rooted in political economy, such as exploitation, and also injustices rooted in culture, such as “cultural imperialism.” She thus follows contemporary “post-socialist” social-movement thought in giving considerable attention to culture. Yet she refuses to follow those extreme culturalists who would jettison altogether a focus on political economy. She insists, rather, on maintaining a “quasi-socialist” interest in that problematic as well. Indeed, it is this dual focus, this interest in both recognition and redistribution, that marks the innovation, and the promise, of her book.

Thus, Young’s critique of “the distributive paradigm” should not be taken entirely at face value. In my view, this critique is ambiguous and confused. In one aspect, it recapitulates the Marxian objection to approaches that focus exclusively on end-state patterns of allocation among individuals of tangible goods and positions, such as income and jobs or offices, while neglecting the underlying structural processes that produce them. Here the target is “the standpoint of distribution,” as opposed to “the standpoint of production.” In another aspect, however, Young recapitulates Amartya Sen’s objection to approaches that focus on the distribution of commodities, as opposed to capabilities, thereby casting people as passive consumers instead of as agents.² Here the critique is aimed, not at distribution *per se*, but at distribution of the wrong goods. In a third aspect, finally, Young’s critique is aimed precisely at approaches, like Sen’s, that treat nontangibles such as capabilities as foci and objects of distribution. Here the target is “reification.”

²See, for example, Amartya Sen, *Commodities and Capabilities* (Amsterdam: North-Holland, 1985).

No matter how we resolve these ambiguities, the important point is this: none of Young's objections to "the distributive paradigm" constitutes a persuasive argument against approaches that assess the justice of social arrangements in terms of how they distribute economic advantages and disadvantages. Although made from the "standpoint of distribution," such judgments need not entail that remedies for injustice be limited to such measures as equalizing income through redistributive taxation. Instead, they can provide good reasons for condemning the underlying "basic structure" of a society and for seeking its wholesale transformation. Young herself makes such judgments throughout her book. In so doing, she generally follows Sen in defining economic advantage and disadvantage in terms of capabilities. This, however, puts her squarely inside the distributive paradigm, broadly conceived, her qualms about reification notwithstanding. Nor could she escape that paradigm with respect to socio-economic justice, finally, by opposing its extension to issues of cultural justice as well. Rather, as I shall show, she effectively adds a second, recognition problematic alongside it. Despite Young's explicit caveats, then, redistribution remains relevant to *Justice and the Politics of Difference*.

If redistribution represents an implicit presence in Young's book, then recognition constitutes its gravitational center. The recognition paradigm undeniably dominates the book, reflecting Young's identification with contemporary new social movements. Her stated aim is, in fact, to explicate, and defend, the theory of justice that is implicit in the political practice of movements such as feminism, gay and lesbian liberation, and anti-racism. What is distinctive about these movements, as she presents them, is their view of the dominant culture as a locus of oppression, their rejection of the "ideal of assimilation," and their demand for the recognition of difference. Theorizing cultural recognition is therefore central to the project of Young's book.

Accordingly, Young mounts a challenge to theories that would exclude the domain of culture from the scope of justice. She makes a compelling case for the view that the dominant images, symbolic associations, and interpretations of a culture may denigrate and degrade some social groups; they may even find expression in unconscious and preconscious reactions of bodily aversion in everyday life in ways that constitute serious harm. Culture, therefore, may be oppressive and unjust. No theory of justice can with justice ignore it.

Young also follows contemporary movements in defending the "politics of difference." By this she means a "cultural revolution" in which social group differences cease to be viewed as deviations from a single norm and are seen, rather, as cultural variations. Far from seeking to abolish such differences, then, Young aims to preserve and affirm them. This politics of difference is so central to her vision that it appears in the title of her book. It is her distinctive politics of recognition.

Despite her continuing interest in the politics of redistribution, then, Young's primary focus is the politics of recognition. She returns to the latter again and

again, in virtually every chapter of the book. By contrast, her treatment of political economy is somewhat cursory. To be sure, at least three of the five forms of oppression that Young identifies are based in political economy, but that domain receives only one chapter-length elaboration—namely, in the chapter that criticizes “the myth of merit” and the division between task-defining and task-executing labor. Virtually every other chapter, in contrast, focuses primarily on cultural oppression and its remedy, the “politics of difference.”

The dominance of the cultural paradigm over the political-economy paradigm is not merely a matter of length of treatment, however. It can also be read in some of Young’s central categorical conceptions, as indeed can some unresolved tensions between the cultural and the political-economic dimensions of her framework.

II. DEFINING OPPRESSION

Consider, first, Young’s general definition of oppression as “the institutional constraint on self-development” (37). To be oppressed, in her view, is to be inhibited from “developing and exercising one’s capacities and expressing one’s experience” (37). More elaborately: “Oppression consists in systematic institutional processes which prevent some people from learning and using satisfying and expansive skills in socially recognized settings, or institutional processes which inhibit people’s ability to play and communicate with others or to express their feelings and perspectives on social life in contexts where others can listen” (38).

There are many interesting and attractive features of this definition. The focus on capacities, for example, provides a welcome corrective to approaches that focus on resource distribution and implicitly posit people as inactive consumers. As I noted, this point recalls Amartya Sen’s argument in *Commodities and Capabilities*.

For present purposes, however, I want to focus on something else: the two-pronged or bipartite character of the definition, the way in which it turns one of its two faces toward problems of culture and the other toward problems of political economy. The cultural face of the definition is captured in the clauses that concern constraints on “expressing one’s experience,” and processes “which inhibit people’s ability to play and communicate with others or to express their feelings and perspectives on social life in contexts where others can listen.” These clauses define oppression as inhibited expression and communication, rooted in a lack of cultural recognition. The political-economic face, in contrast, appears in the clauses about constraints on “developing and exercising one’s capacities,” and “systematic institutional processes which prevent some people from learning and using satisfying and expansive skills in socially recognized settings.” These clauses define oppression as inhibited development of expansive skills, rooted in inequities in the division of labor.

Here, then, we see Young's dual focus on redistribution and recognition. She has sought to yoke culture and political economy together under a single, albeit bipartite, definition of oppression. But the two sides are not adequately integrated with one another. And the definition contains an unresolved tension. The cultural dimension of the definition suggests that the capacities and abilities of oppressed people are essentially undamaged and intact; they suffer chiefly from misrecognition and undervaluation of their group-specific modes of cultural expression. The political-economy face, in contrast, suggests that certain skill-developing capacities and abilities of the oppressed are stunted or unrealized; they suffer from lack of opportunity to grow, learn and enhance their skills in socially valued work. The cultural face of the definition, then, is a problem of undervaluation; the political-economic face, in contrast, is a problem of underdevelopment.

These two understandings of oppression are clearly in tension with one another. And the tension has significant political consequences. Arrangements that positively affirm the culture of oppressed groups constitute a plausible remedy for the cultural face of oppression. But they are far less plausible as a remedy for the political-economic face. To remedy that face of oppression, opportunities for self-development are required. Recognition of cultural difference, in sum, is no substitute for redistribution. In some cases, we shall see, it could interfere with the latter.

Young appears not to notice this problem. But it surfaces repeatedly throughout her book. Not just oppression, but also other key conceptions, evince a bipartite structure. In them, too, as we shall see, cultural and political-economic elements are unself-consciously mixed, but not successfully integrated with one another. Consequently, those conceptions, too, manifest theoretical tensions, which ultimately call into question Young's politics of difference.

III. DEFINING A SOCIAL GROUP

Consider, as another example, Young's conception of a social group. Groups, according to her, are the entities that suffer oppression. Individuals are oppressed in virtue of belonging to oppressed groups. Groups, moreover, are prior to individuals in that they are constitutive of individual identities. Groups in Young's sense, then, are neither aggregates, which are classified externally by an observer on the basis of objective similarities, nor voluntary associations, which individuals might join or not join, without any shifts in their identities. Rather, in Young's words: "a social group is a collective of persons differentiated from at least one other group by *cultural forms, practices, or ways of life*. Members of a group have a specific affinity with one another *because of their similar experience or way of life*, which prompts them to associate with one another more than with those not identified with the group, or in a different way" (43, my emphasis). Elsewhere: "a social group is a collective of people who have affinity with one another *because*

of a set of practices or way of life. They differentiate themselves from or are differentiated by at least one other group *according to these cultural forms*" (186, my emphasis).³

This conception, too, has many attractive features. For example, it neatly bypasses all the dilemmas associated with the standard Marxian distinction between the class-in-itself, defined by its objective structural position, and the class-for-itself, defined as the group's accurate subjective awareness of its objective position. Young's idea of an affinity group is reducible neither to an objective position nor to its reflection in consciousness. Rather, it is a lived sense of connection and differentiation.

How, then, does group differentiation arise? On what precisely is lived affinity based? In the passages quoted above, Young refers alternatively to "cultural forms," "ways of life," "similar experiences," and "set(s) of practices." These expressions, although somewhat vague, suggest that groups may be formed in a variety of different ways and on a multiplicity of different bases. Elsewhere in her book, in fact, Young elaborates several different scenarios. She notes that in some cases the affinities that comprise a social group arise simply as a result of shared cultural forms; an example is an ethnic group. In other cases, however, Young claims that group affinities can arise as a result of people's shared position in the division of labor; here, interestingly, she mentions gender as an example. In still other cases, finally, she suggests that group affinities may arise even in the absence of a shared culture or a shared position in the division of labor, as the result of a shared experience of hostility from the outside. This sort of group affinity is constituted when members of another group brand people as "Other" from without and proceed to oppress them; here Young cites the example of assimilated German Jews under Nazism.

Once again, we find that Young invokes a single conception to cover both cultural and political-economic phenomena. Her notion of a social group, too, is bipartite. It encompasses both those modes of collectivity, such as ethnicity, that are rooted in culture alone, and also those modes of collectivity, such as class, that are rooted in political economy. Young apparently sees no need to maintain such distinctions. For our purposes, however, it will be useful to avoid collapsing them, at least until we have had a chance to interrogate them.

Let me therefore introduce the following terminology: Insofar as group affinity rests on shared cultural forms, I shall call the result "a culture-based group." Insofar as affinity rests on shared position in the division of labor, in contrast, I

³Young also gives another definition: "What makes a group a group is a social process of interaction and differentiation in which some people come to have a particular affinity with one another. My affinity group in a given social situation comprises those *people with whom I feel most comfortable, who are more familiar*. Affinity names the manner of *sharing assumptions, affective bonding, and networking* that recognizably differentiates groups from one another..." (172, my emphasis)

shall call the result "a political-economy-based group." To repeat: the best familiar model for the culture-based group is the ethnic group. The best model for the political-economy based group, in contrast, is class, especially the lived experience of social class theorized by Pierre Bourdieu as "class habitus," which is not limited to the classes recognized by Marxism.⁴ In Young's framework, as we saw, this distinction disappears. Nevertheless, insofar as it encompasses both culture-based groups and political-economy-based groups, her conception of a social group is bipartite.

The bipartite character of Young's conception is simultaneously appealing and troubling. The appeal is the attraction of parsimony—the possibility that a single conception might encompass several disparate modes of collectivity. The difficulty is the possibility that it might not do justice to them all. It could be the case, for example, that important conceptual distinctions will be lost if we assimilate genders, “races,” ethnic groups, sexualities, nationalities, and social classes to the single model of the affinity group. It could also be the case that one of these modes of collectivity will implicitly predominate, that its distinctive characteristics will be projected as characteristics of all social groups, and that other modes of collectivity will be distorted.

This does in fact happen in the course of Young's argument. She implicitly privileges the culture-based social group. As a result, the ethnic group surreptitiously becomes the paradigm not only for such collectivities as Jews, Arab-Americans, and Asian-Americans, where it is clearly apt, but also for such collectivities as gays and lesbians, women, African Americans, old people, people with disabilities, Native Americans, and working-class people, where it distorts.

This, too, has unfortunate political consequences. The politics of difference embraced by Young is a vision of emancipation especially suited to the situation of ethnic groups. Where the differences in question are those of ethnic cultures, it is *prima facie* plausible to consider that justice would be served by affirming them and thereby fostering cultural diversity. Where, in contrast, cultural differences are linked to differentially desirable locations in the political economy, a politics of difference may be misplaced. There justice may require precisely undermining group differentiation by, for example, restructuring the division of labor. In that case, redistribution could obviate the need for recognition.

It is true, of course, that modelling the character of oppressed groups on ethnicity fits the self-understanding of many of the new social movements Young supports. Thus, in settling on such a conception, she has succeeded in her professed aim of articulating the implicit theories of such groups. At the same time, however, to the extent that these movements may misunderstand

⁴For class habitus, see, for example, Pierre Bourdieu, *Distinction: A Social Critique of the Judgement of Taste*, trans. Richard Nice (Cambridge, Mass.: Harvard University Press, 1984).

themselves, she risks reproducing their self-misunderstandings. In noting this, I mean to signal a broader unease with a theoretical stance that could be too closely identified with its subjects to be critical of their self-understandings.

Equally troubling, there is something specifically, and even quintessentially, American about this way of understanding collectivities. Where else but in the United States does ethnicity so regularly eclipse class, nation and party? This, of course, is not an infeasible criticism of Young's concept of a social group, but it should give one pause about its applicability.

IV. FIVE FACES OF OPPRESSION

I have already noted that Young disclaims the sort of categorial dualism I have been at pains to uncover in her book. Instead, she proposes a five-part classification of oppressions, which purports to scramble the distinction between culture and political economy. In this section, I examine her classificatory schema in order to show that it, too, is implicitly bipartite.

Young's classification of oppressions is perhaps the most interesting part of her book. With this classification she aims to circumvent painful and unproductive squabbles among oppressed groups as to whose oppression is "primary" and whose merely "secondary," whose, therefore, should be prioritized in political struggle and whose should be put on the back-burner. Her inspired move is to reconceptualize what it means to theorize oppression. Instead of classifying oppressions in terms of who suffers them, and thus, distinguishing such varieties as sexism, racism, ableism and homophobia, she classifies different types of capacity-inhibition. Only then will she ask which groups suffer which kind(s) of oppression? This approach generates five distinct "faces" or forms of oppression, which may attach to groups singly or in various combinations or permutations. Each of the five is a sufficient condition for calling a group oppressed; none is a necessary condition.

Very briefly, the five forms of oppression identified by Young are:

1. *Exploitation*, defined as a structural relation whereby some people exercise their capacities under the control of others, according to the purposes and for the benefit of others, thereby systematically augmenting the power of the others. Exploitation in Young's view is not restricted to Marxian class relations. It also occurs in gender-specific and race-specific forms, in unpaid activities as well as in paid work⁵. The remedy for exploitation, according to Young, is radical restructuring of both political economy and culture.

⁵For an account that uses game-theoretical tools to construct a conception of exploitation that applies to gender as well as class, see Alan Carling, *Social Division* (London: Verso, 1991).

2. *Marginalization*, defined as the condition of expulsion or exile from the system of labor and from useful participation in social life. Those who suffer marginalization, according to Young, include the racially marked underclass, the old, youth, the disabled, and single mothers and their children. The harm of this oppression includes not only material deprivation but also curtailment of citizenship rights and loss of opportunities for developing and exercising capacities in socially recognized ways. The remedy is political-economic restructuring.

3. *Powerlessness*, defined as the condition of having power exercised over one by others without oneself exercising power in turn; hence, having to take orders but never oneself giving them; occupying a position in the division of labor that affords little opportunity to develop and exercise skills; and being subject as a result to disrespectful treatment because of low occupational status; being viewed, moreover, as lacking "respectability." This oppression is, according to Young, suffered by nonprofessional workers. Its remedy is radical restructuring of the division of labor to eliminate the division between task-defining and task-executing work.

4. *Cultural imperialism*, defined as the universalization and establishment as the norm of the dominant group's experience and culture, which has the result of rendering invisible the oppressed group's perspective, while simultaneously stereotyping that group as Other. Cultural imperialism is suffered by women, African Americans, Native Americans, gays and lesbians, and many other social groups in contemporary society. The best remedy for this form of oppression, according to Young, is "the politics of difference," or attention to and affirmation of social group differences.

5. *Violence*, defined as susceptibility to systematic, albeit random, irrational, unconsciously motivated, and socially tolerated attacks on group members' persons and property. Included here are physical attacks, to be sure, but also harassment, intimidation and ridicule. Violence, according to Young, is closely related to cultural imperialism. Many groups that suffer the latter also suffer the former, for example, gays and lesbians, Jews, African Americans, Latinos and women. The remedy for it, too, is cultural revolution: changes in the images, stereotypes, and the mundane gestures of everyday life wherein oppressed people meet aversive reactions to their bodily presence.

Each of these five definitions of the forms of oppression is extremely interesting and deserves some individual attention. Here, however, I shall consider only the general configuration. Young presents the five as distinct faces of oppression, and she declines to explore possible connections among them. We may note, however, that they fall broadly into two groups. Exploitation, marginalization and powerlessness are rooted in political economy; they involve inhibition of the sort of self-development that Young believes comes from meaningful, skill-enhancing and socially valued work. Cultural imperialism and violence, in contrast, are said

by Young to be rooted in culture; they involve inhibition with respect to expression and communication.

Here, then, is another bipartite schema. Some oppressions (exploitation, marginalization and powerlessness) are rooted in political economy; others (cultural imperialism and violence) are rooted in culture. Again, Young herself does not make this distinction. But for my purposes it will be useful to develop it. Let me therefore introduce the following terminology: those instances of oppression that are rooted in political economy I shall call "economically-rooted oppressions." Those that are rooted in culture, in contrast, I shall call "culturally-rooted oppressions."

Each of these two broad categories of oppressions has its own proper broad category of remedy. The remedy for the culturally-rooted oppressions of cultural imperialism and violence, according to Young, is cultural revolution. This means breaking down the idea of a single universal set of cultural norms and affirming cultural pluralism and difference. The principal remedy for the economically-rooted oppressions, on the other hand, is radical restructuring of the division of labor. This includes eliminating the division between, for example, task-defining and task-executing work and providing socially valued, skill-enhancing activities for all.

Each of these remedies seems well-suited to redress its respective oppressions—assuming that we follow Young's characterizations. But there is a potentially harmful tension between them. Whereas the remedy for the culturally-rooted oppressions promotes group differentiation, the remedy for the economically-rooted oppressions may undermine it. In some cases, consequently, the effects of the two remedies will be contradictory.

The problem becomes evident when we take a closer look at the oppressions of cultural imperialism and violence. As we saw, Young's definitions suggested that both of them were culturally rooted and, hence, best remedied by the politics of difference. This, however, begs the question.

Consider, first, that Young's account of cultural imperialism contains an important ambiguity. She defines this oppression as the universalization of the particular culture of the dominant group. But she does not specify the grounds of that group's dominance. One possibility, of course, is that its dominance consists precisely in the fact that its culture is universalized; in that case, cultural imperialist oppression would be culturally rooted. Another possibility, however, is that the group's dominance arises in some other way, such as through political-economic superordination, which then provides the basis for the universalization of its culture; in that case, cultural imperialist oppression would be economically rooted.⁶ In the first case, moreover, affirmation of cultural difference is a plausible remedy for oppression. In the second case, however, political-economic

⁶There are other possibilities as well. A group's dominance could also be rooted in numerical superiority, military superiority, and/or political domination, any of which could then give rise to its cultural dominance. For the sake of simplicity, I leave aside these other possibilities here.

restructuring is necessary. In that case, consequently, the politics of difference could be counterproductive, as it tends to preserve those group differences that redistribution could well undermine. Recognition, in sum, could work against redistribution.

Analogous problems arise with respect to the oppression of violence. As we saw, violence in Young's definition is closely linked to cultural imperialism as it is said to be fostered by cultural othering. It, too, is thus open to ambiguity. In some instances, oppressive violence may be linked to autonomous processes of cultural othering; violence against gays is an example. In other cases, however, violence may be fostered by forms of cultural othering that are themselves in turn rooted in political economy; the lynching of Blacks in the Jim Crow South is an example. In still other cases, finally, oppressive violence may flow directly out of political-economic oppression, with little or no intermediary cultural othering; violence against (ethnically-majoritarian) unionizing and striking workers is an example. It follows that oppressive violence is not always best remedied by recognizing cultural difference. While clearly appropriate in the case of violence against gays, the politics of difference may be counterproductive in the case of violence against strikers, where the primary need is redistribution. The case of lynching is more complicated, I think, as both recognition and redistribution are needed. Yet it is still true that they stand in tension with one another, and that the first can interfere with the second.

V. APPLICATIONS

The preceding discussion suggests that the politics of difference may be less globally applicable than Young thinks. To illustrate the multiplicity of possibilities here, let us consider some real-world applications that concern different cases of oppressed groups.

First, take the case of working-class nonprofessionals. In Young's account, they suffer primarily the oppression of powerlessness, although presumably also that of exploitation. As a consequence of powerlessness, moreover, they are said to develop a class habitus or affinity that marks them as lacking "respectability." Here, then, is an oppressed group whose existence and whose oppression are both rooted in political economy. Is the politics of difference apposite?

In my view the answer is no. This is because it is unlikely that an affinity group based on the shared experience of powerlessness and non-respectability would survive as a group in the event that its economic oppression were remedied via redistribution. Suppose, for example, that the division of labor between task-defining work and task-executing work were abolished. In that case, all jobs would encompass both sorts of work, and the class division between professionals and nonprofessionals would be abolished. Cultural affinities that differentiate professionals from nonprofessionals would probably wither away as well, since

they appear to have no other basis of existence. Thus, a politics of redistribution that successfully combatted the political-economic oppression of powerlessness would effectively destroy the group as a group, much as Marx claimed that the task of the proletariat was to abolish itself as a class. The politics of difference, in contrast, would not contribute to overcoming oppression in this case. Instead it would interfere with the pursuit of redistribution.

Consider, second, the case of women as an oppressed group. It is doubtful to me that women really do constitute a group in Young's sense of a felt connection of shared experience or affinity. Yet gender is unquestionably a structural principle of the division of labor, and as such it disadvantages women as a group. Let us consider, therefore, the effects of a restructured division of labor on women as an oppressed group. Let us assume, further, that a long-term feminist goal is to subvert the existing gender division of labor, and not merely to elevate the standing of women within it, hence to establish a radical redistribution. Now, if the gender division of labor were effectively abolished, would gender-distinct cultural affinities survive? And if not, is the politics of difference an appropriate remedy for the oppression of women?

This case seems less clear-cut than the previous one. Gender affinities, if indeed they exist, could have additional bases beyond their basis in the division of labor, for example, in socialization, in culture, even in bodily experiences, such as menstruation. Thus, even a successful politics of redistribution might not abolish women as a group. They could still be culturally constructed as different from men and be denigrated and oppressed on that basis. Thus, a politics of difference could be in order here. This raises a further dilemma, however. The struggle to remedy women's cultural oppression by affirming women's "difference" on the model of ethnicity might militate against the struggle to abolish the gender division of labor, which entails decreasing the social salience of gender. The first, after all, calls attention to and exaggerates, if it does not performatively create, gender difference. The second, in contrast, would minimize such difference, if not abolish it altogether.

Consider, finally, the case of African Americans. This case seems different yet again. There is little reason to think that abolishing the racial division of labor would entail the disappearance of the affinity group, since that group has an independent cultural basis. A more likely result would be the transformation of a subordinate racialized caste into an ethnic group. And this would be historically new, since African Americans, like Native Americans, have never been allowed to be just another ethnic group.

What these examples show, I think, is that disadvantaged social collectivities differ from one another importantly—both in their bases of differentiation and also in the roots of their oppression. In some cases, political-economic restructuring seems certain to entail group dedifferentiation, while in others it clearly does not. In still other cases, by contrast, the implications are harder to predict.

If this is right, then the politics of difference is not globally applicable. In some cases, such as that of nonprofessional workers, it is simply askew of the nature of the group and its oppression. In other cases, in contrast, such as gays and lesbians, the politics of difference is absolutely crucial for remedying oppression. The hardest cases, of course, are those, such as gender and “race,” in which both redistribution and recognition are required to overcome a complex of oppression that is multiple and multiply-rooted. The difficulty here stems from the real tensions and interferences that arise when one tries both to affirm and to abolish difference simultaneously. A glib and global endorsement of the politics of difference will not help us solve this problem. For that, we need to face the problem squarely and to develop a *critical* theory of recognition.

VI. CONCLUSION: TOWARD A DIFFERENTIATED POLITICS OF DIFFERENCE AND A CRITICAL THEORY OF RECOGNITION

We have seen that the “politics of difference” is less globally applicable than Young thinks. In the case of some groups and some oppressions, such a politics is clearly apposite. In the case of others, however, such a politics may be counterproductive, since their oppressions may be better combatted precisely by undermining the conditions of existence that differentiate the group as a group. Classes, subordinated sexualities, genders, subordinate racialized castes and ethnic groups represent conceptually distinct kinds of collectivities. Not all of them are suitable vehicles for “the politics of difference.” (Nor of course are what we might call “bad groups,” such as neo-Nazi skinheads, who are certainly oppressed in Young’s terms, since they suffer marginalization and cultural imperialism, but whose “differences” we do not wish to affirm.)

One might accept what I have said so far and still defend the broader applicability of the politics of difference. One might maintain that even where this politics is not a tenable long-term goal, it is indispensable as a transitional strategy. One might claim, for example, that this politics promotes group solidarity and thus is a necessary condition for the possibility of any sort of political struggle whatsoever.

It is certainly true that one cannot stand up for oneself when one is crippled by self-hatred. But it does not follow that affirming one’s difference in Young’s sense is the only or best way of overcoming internalized self-hatred. Here the history of second-wave feminism is instructive. The radical consciousness-raising of the late 1960s and early 1970s helped heal wounds, forge solidarity and galvanize struggle. But it was a far cry from the sort of cultural feminism in vogue today, which celebrates the traditional feminine. It is far from clear, moreover, that the latter really does foster solidarity of the sort that coheres with the long-term goal of debinarizing gender. It seems rather to have led to fractiousness and hurt by affirming traits specific to white middle class heterosexual women and by promoting repressive forms of “correctness.”

Young counterposes her ideal of the politics of difference to what she calls “the assimilationist ideal,” which, she argues, perpetuates oppression. But are these really the only two possibilities? My argument suggests they are not. In order to convey a sense of additional possibilities, let me conclude by contrasting four possible attitudes towards “difference.”

1. The first is the one Young calls humanism: it is the view that the differences that members of oppressed groups evince are precisely the damages of oppression or the lies that rationalize them. Difference, in other words, is an artifact of oppression, as in the stunting of skills and capacities. The proper political response is to abolish it. This is essentially the position of Catharine MacKinnon with respect to gender difference.

2. A second position on difference is sometimes called cultural nationalism. Within feminism, it has been called (by Young) gynocentrism; within anti-racist politics, it has been called “Afrocentrism.” It is the view that the differences that members of oppressed groups evince are marks of their cultural superiority over their oppressors. These differences, like feminine nurturance or Native American connection to the land, merit revaluation. But this does not mean that they should be celebrated as differences. On the contrary, they should be universalized and extended to those who currently manifest inferior traits such as competitiveness and instrumentalism. This position can be represented by Sonya Johnson and some (mis)interpreters of Carol Gilligan.

3. A third position views difference as cultural variation. This is the view that the differences manifested by members of different groups are neither superiorities nor inferiorities but simply variations. They should neither be eliminated nor universalized but rather affirmed as differences; they are valuable as expressions of human diversity. This is Young’s position.

4. A fourth position, which is the one I wish to commend, is that there are different kinds of differences. Some differences are of type 1 and should be eliminated; others are of type 2 and should be universalized; still others are of type 3 and should be enjoyed. This position implies that we can make judgments about which differences fall into which categories. It also implies that we can make normative judgments about the relative value of alternative norms, practices and interpretations, judgments which could lead to conclusions of inferiority, superiority and equivalent value. It militates against any politics of difference that is wholesale and undifferentiated. Put differently, it entails a different—and differentiated—politics of difference.

Such a differentiated view of difference would be an important contribution to a critical theory of recognition. It would help us to identify, and defend, only those versions of the politics of difference that coherently synergize with the politics of redistribution. This is the sort of approach we need in order to meet the challenges of our time. The task is to integrate the egalitarian ideals of the socialist paradigm with whatever is genuinely emancipatory in the paradigm of recognition.